

Money Mistake: *You're Living a Fast, Wild Life*

The Fix: *Slow Down Before You Pay the Price*

Being a speed demon will cost you. When I was a teenager, I had a friend who managed to get 10 speeding tickets over a one-year period. Not only did this do catastrophic damage to her driving record, it cost her over \$3,000 to pay the fines and take the required drivers' safety classes. She didn't just burn rubber—she burned money and time.

If you drive with a lead foot, I strongly suggest you to find a better place for your “talents” than the open road—namely, the video game console in your home. Out of 2,227 motor vehicle fatalities in Canada in 2010, 234 were between the ages of 15 and 19. That's over 10 percent. So when I talk about “paying the price,” I'm not just talking about shelling out a few thousand bucks for speeding tickets. I'm talking about paying the ultimate price: your life.

Parking tickets, though far less dangerous, are another hidden cost. In the early 1980s, I was just another irresponsible kid. At the time, I had a job downtown, so when I went to work, I always parked in the same spot on the street. I guess it wasn't technically a parking spot, because I collected over 400 parking tickets. I had an old sewing table my mother gave me, and one of the drawers was a perfect fit for the tickets. Every time I got another parking ticket, I would pop it right into that drawer and never think about it again. “They'll never catch me,” I told my friends. Every once in a while, I'd change my address so they couldn't track me down. I did that for three years.

Then one day, I received a notice in the mail telling me I wasn't going to be able to renew my license. All the unpaid parking tickets sitting in that drawer had gone into a penalty phase. That was bad news, since I had to drive to work every day. I put on a suit, went downtown to the fines office and begged for mercy. Eventually, they agreed to settle. It cost me \$4,500. See? I haven't always been good with money. I learned the hard way so you don't have to.